

Ἀνώνυμος Ἐπικούρειος

Epicurean Anonymous: Fragments from the Herculaneum Papyri

eul_aid: jtm

Period: Ἑλληνιστική Hellenistic

Dialect: Κοινή Koine (phi, frg)

Domain: Φιλοσοφία Philosophy

Format: Πραγματεία Treatise

Affiliation: Epicurean

This author is an anonymous follower of the Epicurean school of philosophy, likely active in the 3rd century BCE, shortly after the death of its founder, Epicurus. No personal details about their life are known.

Their significance comes entirely from two fragmentary treatises preserved in the library of the Villa of the Papyri at Herculaneum, which was buried by the eruption of Mount Vesuvius in 79 CE. The two known works are **On Choices and Avoidances**, which deals with the Epicurean ethical pursuit of pleasure and avoidance of pain, and **On Death**, which argues that death is nothing to be feared. Both texts are written in the common Greek of the period and survive only as damaged papyrus scrolls. Their presence in the library of the later Epicurean philosopher Philodemus suggests they were valued within the school for teaching core doctrines.

According to modern scholars, this anonymous author provides a crucial window into how Epicurean ideas were explained and defended by early followers. The works exemplify the school's practice of prioritizing the clear transmission of philosophy over individual fame. They serve as important sources for understanding the development of Epicurean thought between the writings of Epicurus himself and later figures like the Roman poet Lucretius.

Works (2)

- Ἀποσπάσματα περὶ Πυθοκλέους καὶ Φύσεως · Fragments on Pythocles and Nature · 37 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα Περὶ Ἡρ. 176 · Fragments Pertaining to Herculaneum Papyri · 33 passages

Other Epicurean Authors

- Καρνεῖσκος ὁ Ἐπικούρειος · Carneiscus the Epicurean · 2 works
- Διογένης ὁ Οἰνοανδεύς · Diogenes of Oenoanda · 1 work
- Ἐπίκουρος ὁ φιλόσοφος · Epicurus the Philosopher · 8 works
- Ἑρμαρχὸς ὁ Μυτιληναῖος · Hermarchus of Mytilene · 1 work
- Μητρόδωρος ὁ Λαμψακηνός · Metrodorus of Lampsacus the Elder · 1 work
- Φιλόδημος ὁ Γαδαρεύς · Philodemus of Gadara · 6 works
- Πολύστρατος ὁ Ἐπικούρειος · Polystratus the Epicurean · 2 works